

Photographs by DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

MADAM CM'S LOYALISTS
Far left, West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee; ministers Chandrima Bhattacharya (left) and Shashi Panja at an Iftar meeting in Kolkata, Apr. 21, 2022

This year, like every other year, International Women's Day on March 8 was marked by solemn declarations of women's rights and gender equality, celebration of the socio-political and cultural achievements of women, and recognition of the barriers to be overcome still. It was also blithely used by commercial establishments to peddle their fare. But in India, women still constitute only 15 per cent of the 545 MPs in the Lok Sabha; in the Rajya Sabha, they are 14 per cent. Lawmakers continue to be indifferent to the Women's Reservation Bill—seeking to reserve one-third of the seats in the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies—that was tabled in the Lok Sabha in 2010, after being passed in the Upper House that year. The situation across state legislatures is no better—19 of them have less than 10 per cent women lawmakers. West Bengal, with 40 women legislators (comprising 13.7 per cent of its 294 MLAs), is among the states with the highest proportion of women MLAs. Thirty-three of the state's women MLAs are from the Trinamool Congress (TMC), seven from the BJP. In addition, nine of the TMC's 22 Lok Sabha MPs (40 per cent) are women. Indeed, party chief and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has always put women in the foreground, be it in politics or administration. Now, by handing over two key portfolios—finance, and commerce and industry—to two senior women in her cabinet, Mamata has demonstrated the faith she reposes in her lady colleagues.

Chandrima Bhattacharya was given full charge of the finance department with the rank of minister of state in March 2022 since her predecessor Amit Mitra could not contest the bypolls as required due to ill health after he was made finance minister. Dr Shashi Panja was asked to take over the industry, commerce and enterprise department in August 2022 after the arrest of minister Partha Chatterjee in the alleged teachers' recruitment scam that precipitated a cabinet reshuffle.

Chandrima and Shashi, other than their increasing political heft, are being rewarded for their clean image and steadfast loyalty. After being battered by numerous scandals, the party is trying to promote and project them as part of its image-building exercise. There was a time when Mamata as a street-fighting opposition leader would rely on combative women who could endure the aggression of the Left cadre and then take the fight to the opposite camp. Now, in her third term as chief minister, Mamata needs educated women with a certain refinement to represent Bengal. Chandrima is a lawyer, Shashi a medical doctor by profession.

As chief minister, Mamata has herself held departments like home, health, land and land reforms, hill affairs, minority affairs and, in short spells, finance and industry. With increasing demands on her time, she either engaged separate ministers or got a junior minister to assist her.

Chandrima joined the cabinet in 2012 as a minister of state for health. Soon, she got independent responsibility for the law and judicial department. With her many years of experience as a lawyer, Chandrima has a natural flair for legal minutiae and officials say her room in the state secretariat often turned into